

The Poetics of Platforms

On audio-visual containers and topophilia in platform cultures

Topophilia

(Bachelard 1958)

A place not only experienced in its geometric orderedness but also in the **intimate imaginations** one lives and lived it in.

Containment

(Gumbrecht 2013)

Spatial condition approached in hope of existential protection, a **momentary situation of rest** in life's continuity.

In this understanding, **home** is less the context of a shared language or a social netting one knows and is known in. Rather, underlying these notions, it is **the socio-material environment one repeatedly engages intimately and substantially.**

The Vlog Squad (ensemble / friend group of Los Angeles based content creators)

David Dobrik (Star)



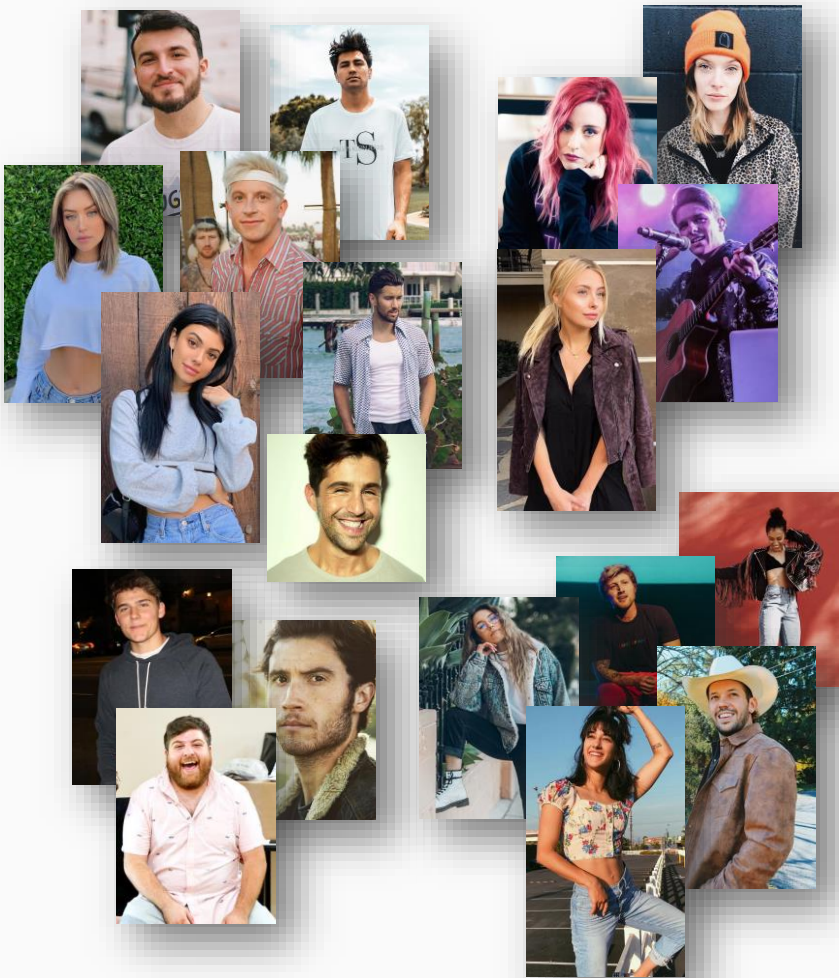
Jason Nash (Co-Star)



Joe (Production Assistant) and Natalie (Personal Assistant / childhood friend of Dobrik)



Jack (Manger) / in 2016 Dobrik signed with WME



David Dobrik (twenty-something hotshot content creator)

He, and most of his friends, rose to initial acclaim on the short-video sharing platform Vine.

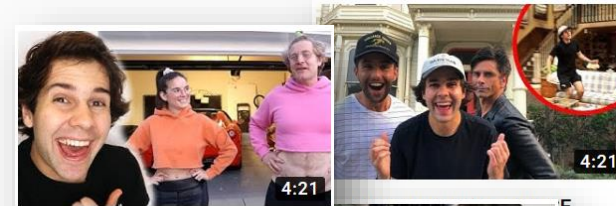
Dobrik's videos are a 4 minute and 20 seconds long montage comprised of skits and comedic segments as fill and one 'banger'.

"Shit you wouldn't dare to do at your own home."

There are a lot of stunts within the videos, like doing a backflip onto a treadmill or riding a slip and slide in the back of a moving semi-truck.

"Oprah Winfrey for white people."

A recurrent theme is Dobrik surprising his LA or hometown friends with cars or large amounts of money as gratitude for supporting his career.



DAD SWITCHES LIVES WITH MY ASSISTANT!!



SERENADING STRANGERS IN THEIR CARS!! (SURPRISE)



SURPRISING FRIEND WITH NEW CAR MAKEOVER!!



SLIP N SLIDE IN BACK OF MOVING TRUCK!!



BACKFLIP ONTO MOVING TREADMILL!! (PAINFUL)



HE DROVE HIS CAR INTO MY LIVING ROOM!! (SURPRISE)



SURPRISING MY ASSISTANT WITH BRAND NEW CAR!!



SURPRISING HER WITH DREAM GIFT!! (EMOTIONAL)



PLAYING ROCK, PAPER, SCISSORS FOR \$10,000!!

Jason Nash (forty-something failed actor and divorced father of two)

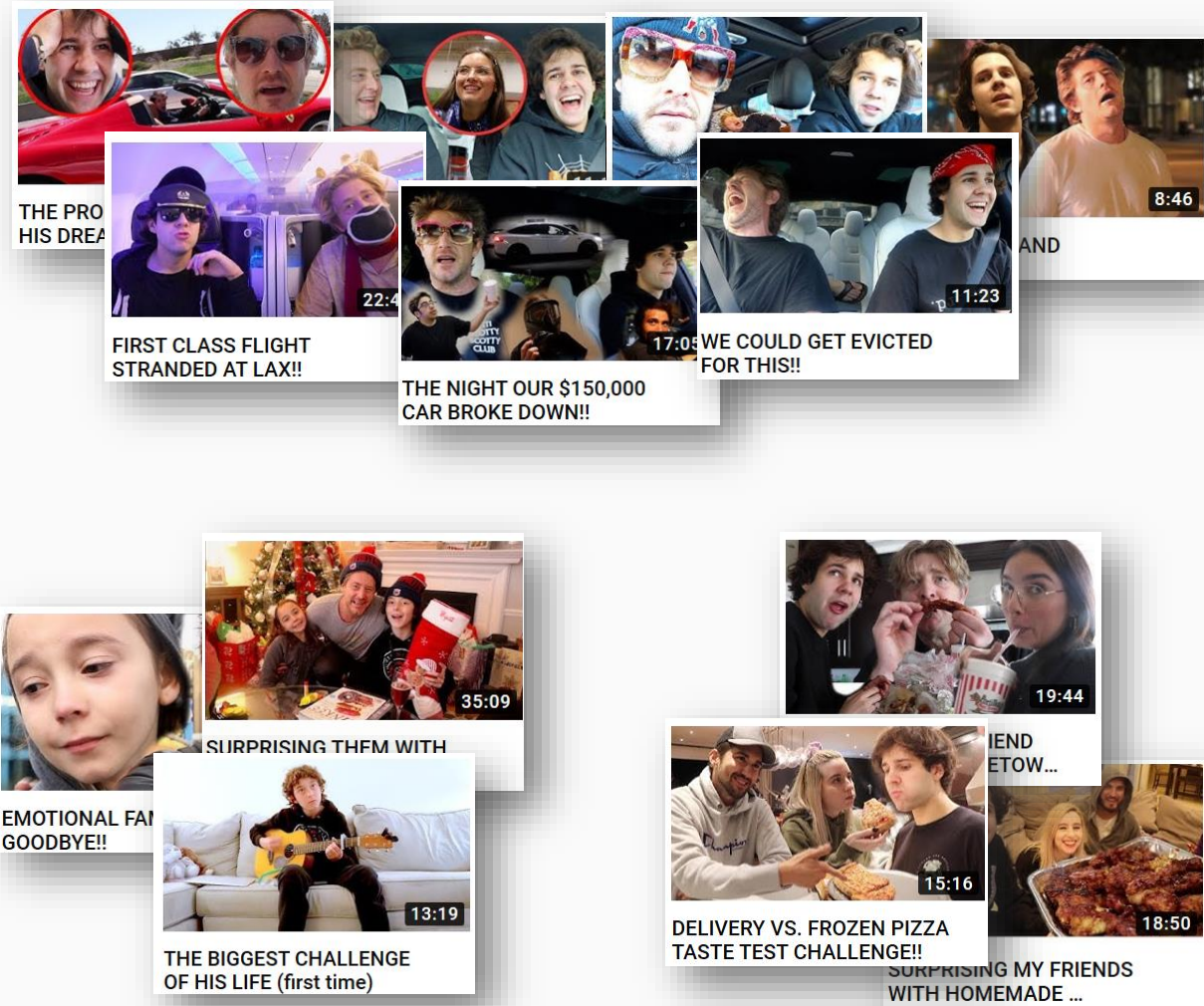
Actor, Director, Comedian – found an audience on Vine.

Early was central performer of Dobrik's videos but also helps film and produce. Both too have podcast and related comedy roadshow.

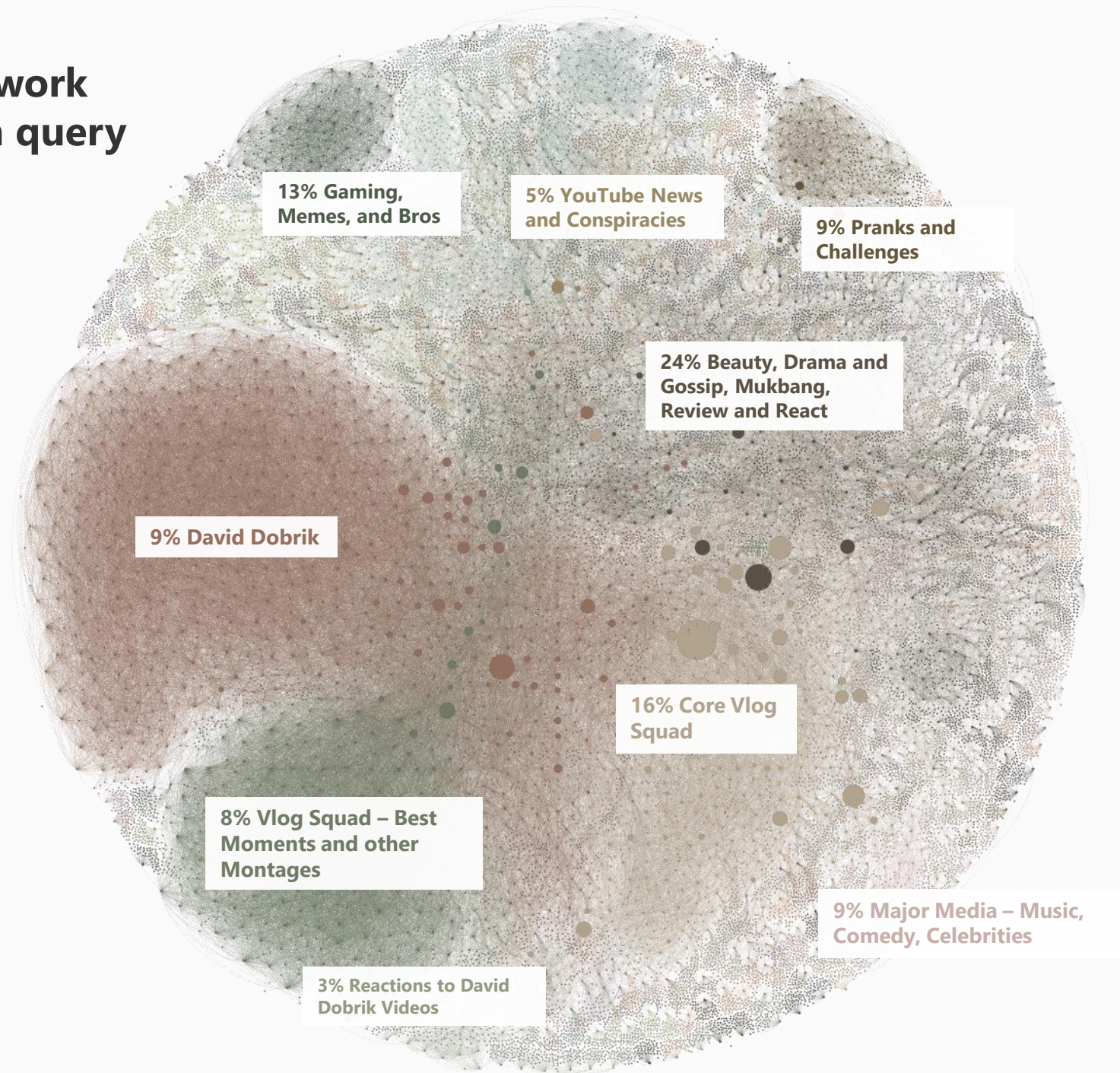
Nash's own videos more slow-paced and narrated counterpart. Often 10 – 30+ mins long. Dobrik is highly selective, Nash picks up everything around.

More 'traditional Vlog' related to personal life and family.

Sometimes also more unscripted and serious style. Especially when spending time with his two kids or family in Boston. Also often brings family theme in his behind the scenes material of the Vlog Squad.

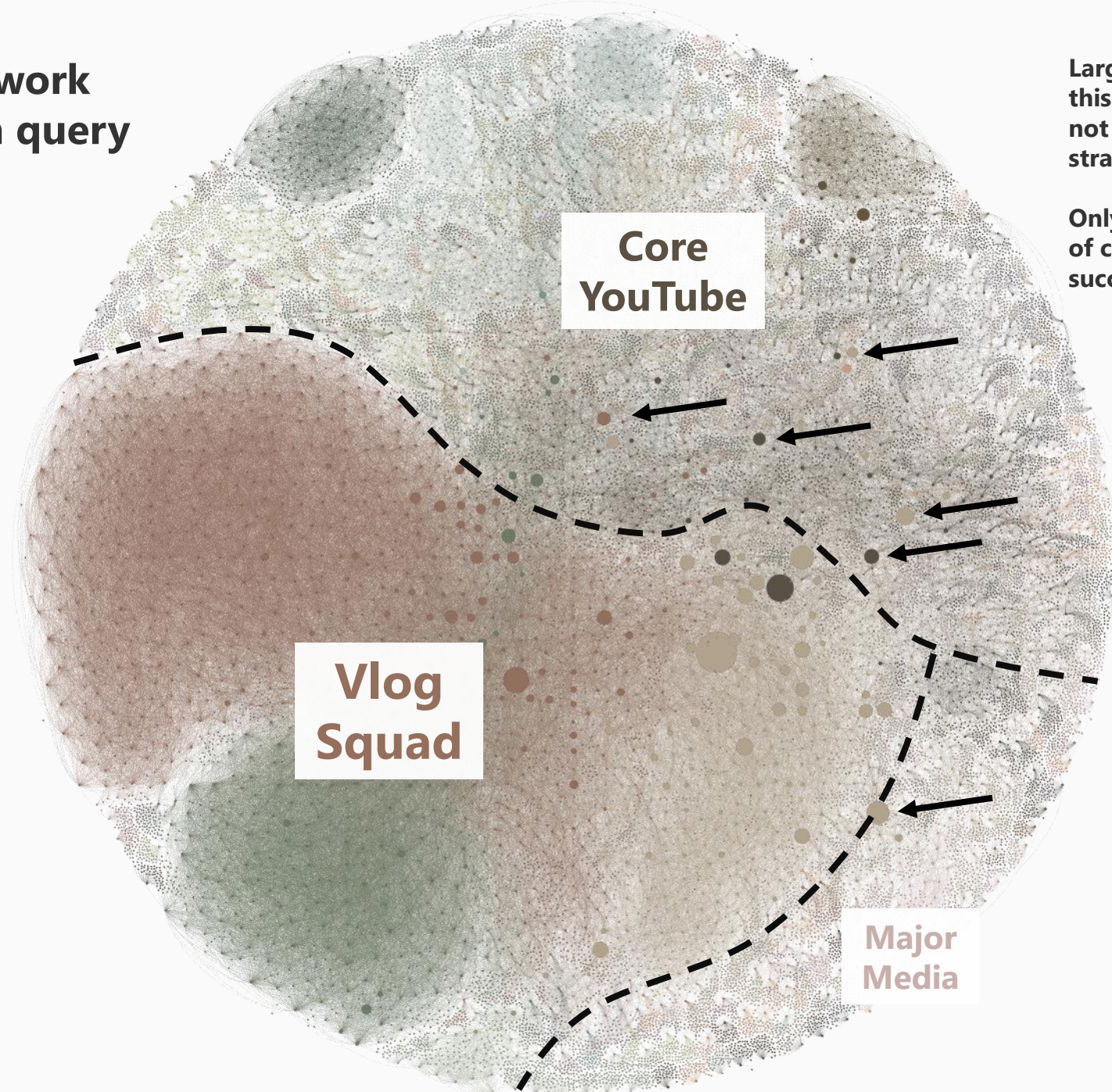


Related videos network
for YouTube search query
“david dobrik”



Nodes	28928
Edges	94302
Clustering coefficient	.17
Average degree	6.3
Diameter	16
Range clustering coefficient within clusters	.01 / .38
Clusters / colour by	Louvain
Node size by	Betweenness
Layout	ForceAtlas2

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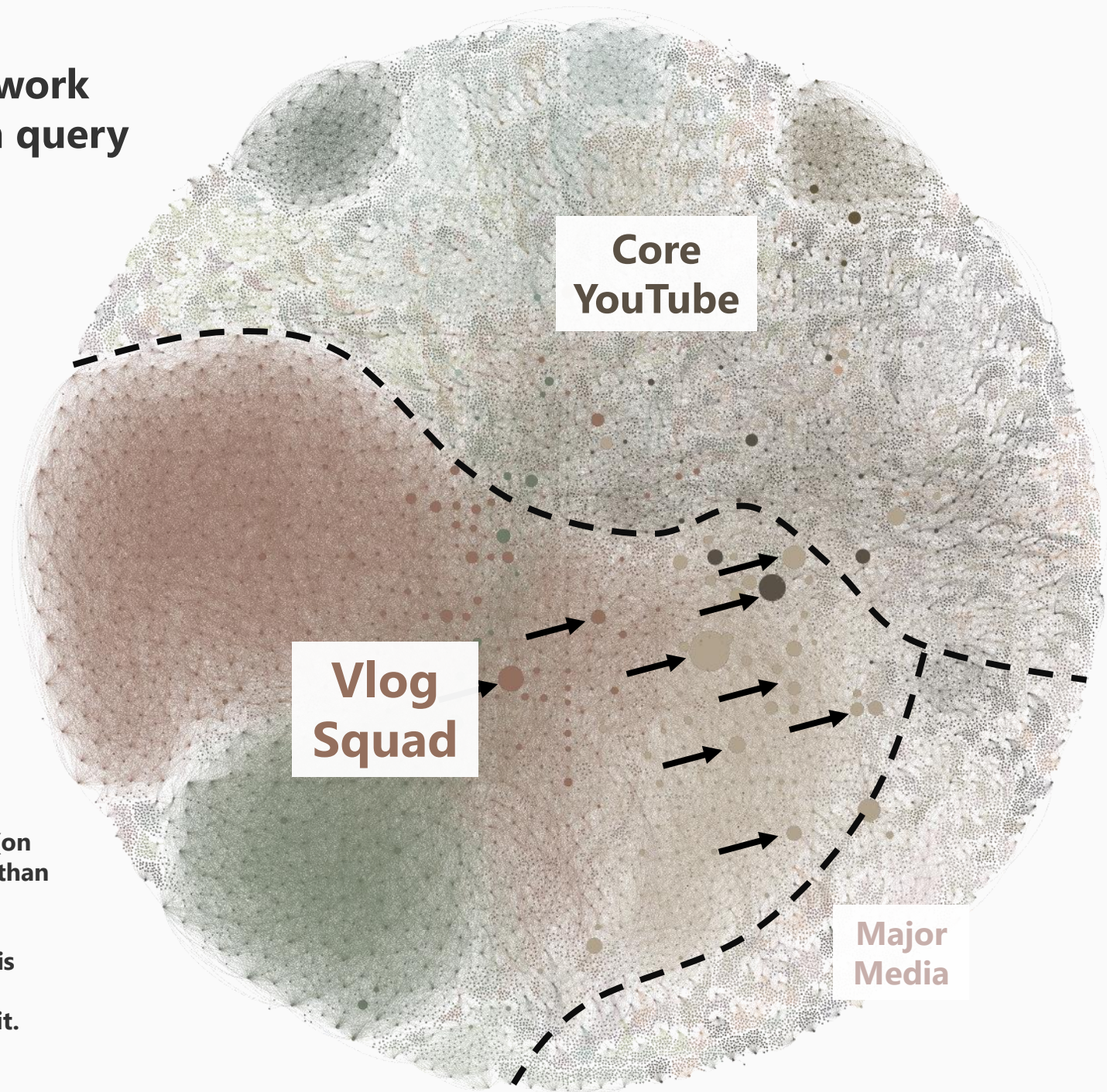


Largest amount of videos within this area of the network. However, not densely connected. Lots of lose strands and bubbles.

Only few weak ties - most in form of collaboration videos - are successful in linking the ecologies.

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The Vlog Squad area is a much more dense network structure (on average 10x more connections than in other clusters).

Many ties established within this area are of also of greater magnitude than those outwith it.

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Dobrik uploads a new video every Monday and Friday. It is then, first for 4 minutes and 20 seconds and maybe another 10 or more minutes, that this complex ecology comes to life. Format and rhythm of the videos create the ground for a present feeling of belonging to emerge. The algorithmic curation of the content flow amplifies and stabilises this experience.

It is only then, when people, just for this short moment, attach their subjective purpose of finding rest to the objective appearance the digital platform and its domain of control create, that digitality manages to wield its ontological powers. It is this form of intimate and substantial interaction that gives rise to those moments of emotional identification in the digital which are constitutive to the self.

Thanks!

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